international cricket as grand theatre, on the big stage. It was hard yakka in near-empty grounds.

I shared a partnership of 165 with Belly in the first Test, during my 836-minute trudge to 263 in the Sheikh Zayed Cricket Stadium in Abu Dhabi. He contributed 63 and had two more scores in the forties as we lost a series we really should have drawn, but when I looked in his eyes towards the end, I knew he was struggling.

The tank was empty. He was running on fumes. I should have pushed for him to take a measured break, when given the chance, because when the game hits you, it hits you hard. I hated that his Test career should end with a six-ball 0, but when we convened the selection meeting for the subsequent tour against South Africa, from mid-December, I argued that we should not take him. That stance wasn't taken lightly, because it had ramifications beyond the numbers. Any team sacrificing a player with 118 caps and 7,727 Test runs is taking a calculated gamble. Discarding such accumulated wisdom was doubly difficult, since it involved someone for whom I had the greatest respect, as a player and person.

As is sometimes the way of things, I tried, and failed, to get through to him on the phone to explain his omission before it became public knowledge. He was obviously the most conspicuous of the five changes we made after that Pakistan series. When we did speak, he was hurt, and disappointed. He told the press he was 'absolutely gutted'.

He hasn't lost his love of cricket. He is far from finished with the game. He will use his experiences, good and bad, to inform his coaching. I appreciate this is no consolation for the way things played out, but the episode made me consider how I would wish to depart when the time came. It was the start of the thought process that ended with that apologetic return to the dressing room at the Oval in 2018.

The immediate challenge was daunting, but not without encouragement. South Africa were a fabulous team, regarded as the best in the world at the time, but showing signs of wear and tear. They had lost three of their four previous Tests going into the series, and were being hunted down in the rankings by India.

Of all the teams we compete against, the South Africans are probably the most similar in terms of temperament. Their ethos is to play cricket hard and have a beer at the end of the game. When we clashed, we did so because we had so much in common. To coin one of Stuart Broad's